> are committed to a body not responsible to Parliament, not appointed by the Crown, but elected by persons who have no more connection with India than consists in the simple possession of so much stock.

He felt that the dual form of government, namely the Company and the Crown, was among the biggest stumbling blocks for ‘unity of purpose’ and expeditious decision-making. There was a significant cross-section of the British Parliament that shared the views of Palmerston; however, he was out of office within a week of the Bill’s introduction in the Parliament and was succeeded by Edward Smith-Stanley, the Earl of Derby. The Bill was ultimately passed in August 1858 and the Act came into force on 2 August 1858.[4]

Before we discuss the salient provisions of the 1858 Act, I will place before the reader extracts from the debates preceding the Act to demonstrate continuity in coloniality. In fact, the debates establish beyond an iota of doubt that the so-called policy of religious neutrality that was adopted by the British after the events of 1857 was, in fact, a restatement of the policy of ‘toleration’, which was discussed in the previous chapters. That this policy translated to grudging and pragmatic toleration of the false religion of the heathen and a tacit support of the true religion of the coloniser was said in as many words during the debates by several members of the British Parliament, in particular by the Archbishop of Canterbury and the Bishops of London and Oxford, who clearly spelt out the nature of their ‘neutrality’, that is, Christian neutrality.

At the third reading of the Bill on 8 July 1858, Samuel Gregson, a member of the House of Commons, observed as under[5]:

> It was a source of satisfaction to him that it had fallen to the lot of the noble Lord (Lord Stanley) to legislate for India, for he had visited India, and knew something about the population over which he was called to rule. *The three great points to which the attention of the Indian Government should be directed, as the seeds of the future prosperity of that empire, were commerce, civilization, and Christianity. He believed the first two would lead to the third, without any extraordinary pressure or exertion.* He had lived amongst the people of India for many years, and believed them to be intelligent, docile, and honest. For many years he had been surrounded by Native